

Thorny devil

Moloch horridus

Secure in its all-over prickly protection, the thorny devil moves with a characteristic slow, swaying, stiff-legged gait. If it senses danger, it stands still, relying on its superb camouflage. Faced with a predator such as a bird of prey or a goanna (a type of monitor lizard), this spiky lizard puffs up its body with air to make itself look bigger—and even harder to swallow. If attacked, it dips its head between its front legs to present the “fake head” on its neck; this fat-filled hump recovers quickly from any minor injury.

Trail meal

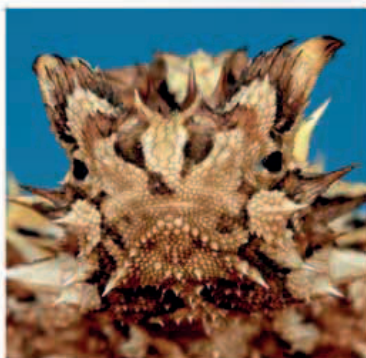
The thorny devil eats ants almost exclusively, feeding during the day, when ants are on the move. A favorite tactic is to locate a trail of foraging worker ants, stand next to it, then lick up each ant in turn, which it chews with its strong, shearing rear teeth. Solitary except when mating, the thorny devil shelters in a burrow or secluded place at night and also for several weeks during midsummer and midwinter. This desert-dweller obtains most of the water that it needs from fog that condenses on its scales when it emerges in the cool hours of early morning.

Thorny devils mate in late winter to early summer, with the smaller males approaching females to see if they are receptive. Females dig a burrow up to 8 in (20 cm) deep, lay 5–10 eggs, and fill it with sand. The hatchlings emerge three to four months later and take up to five years to grow to full size.

- ↔ 6–7 in (15–18 cm)
- ⚖ 7/8–2 oz (25–50 g)
- ⊗ Not known
- 🐜 Ants, other insects
- 🏠 🌵



W. to C. Australia



▷ SPINY EXTERIOR

The thorny devil's overall body coloration darkens in cooler temperatures or when alarmed, and pales when it is warmer or at rest.

◁ WATER CHANNELS

Grooves between the spines collect moisture and channel the water to the corners of the devil's mouth.

tail held upright when walking

Greater bilby

Macrotis lagotis

The only survivor of Australia's six native bandicoot species, the greater bilby inhabited 70 percent of the country before European settlement. Today, mainly due to habitat loss and predation by introduced species such as the domestic cat, it occurs in less than 20 percent of its original range.

A nocturnal marsupial, the bilby uses its strong, three-clawed forelimbs to dig long, spiraling burrows where it sleeps during the day and shelters from dust storms. Huge ears, which give it the alternative name of rabbit-eared bandicoot, help it detect predators and prey, such as termites and ants, which it digs out with its claws. One of its favorite foods is the yalka, or bush onion, a bulb that only germinates in desert soil after fires.



- ↔ 12–22 in (30–56 cm)
- ⚖ 1–6 lb (0.5–2.7 kg)
- ⊗ Vulnerable
- 🐜 Seeds, insects, fruit
- 🏠 🌵



W. to C. Australia

◁ SNIFFING THE AIR

A long, tapering snout and keen sense of smell make up for the bilby's poor eyesight, while long whiskers help bilbies navigate their environment.